# Chapter 14: The Clash of Light and Void

## ** Some wounds don't heal… they just become who you are.**

The arena was still roaring.

Then came the announcement.

"As for the next match… Aruko versus Jesio."

The crowd erupted.

"All the matches with Jesio have been so fast… will this one be the same… or will something change…? We'll find out soon."

Aruko stood still.

His hand resting on his sword.

Not drawn yet.

His eyes calm.

Focused.

Across from him—

Jesio.

Standing the same way.

No expression.

No movement.

As if the result was already decided.

As if this fight—

Was nothing.

Then—

“BEGIN.”

Aruko barely heard it.

Because Jesio was already gone.

A blur.

A shadow—

No.

Faster than that.

Above him.

Mid-air.

Sword already coming down.

“So fast…” Aruko whispered.

Clang.

The strike landed directly on the handle of Aruko’s sword.

The force—

Heavy.

Sharp.

Aruko slid backward.

His feet dragging across the ground.

Before he could even steady himself—

Jesio was already behind him.

No sound.

No warning.

Just there.

The blade came down again—

But this time—

Clang.

Aruko turned and blocked.

Steel met steel.

Both of them pushed—

Then separated.

Sliding in opposite directions.

Silence for a moment.

“Hmph.”

Jesio’s voice.

Low.

Uninterested.

Like none of it mattered.

Aruko exhaled slowly.

His grip tightened.

“…14 works of moon sword.”

His voice was quiet.

But steady.

The blade in his hand—

Started glowing.

A soft light.

Calm.

But deep.

“4th work… Siphon.”

The glow shifted.

Something changed.

Not louder.

Not brighter.

Just—

Different.

Like it was waiting.

Watching.

Aruko lifted his gaze.

“…Let’s see how long you last.”

Jesio didn’t respond.

He moved.

Again.

Faster than before.

No hesitation.

Just raw power.

The strike came down—

Aruko blocked.

Clang.

But this time—

Something was different.

The moment their swords touched—

A faint pull.

Subtle.

But real.

Jesio’s motion—

Slowed.

Just a little.

His body felt—

Heavier.

Like something was being taken.

His eyes narrowed slightly.

The smallest reaction.

But it was there.

Aruko noticed.

And didn’t move.

Didn’t press.

He just held his stance.

Calm.

Waiting.

The sword in his hand—

Drinking.

Silently.

And for the first time—

His motion slowed—just a little.
His body felt heavier.
Like something was being taken.

*…What is this?*
*This isn't damage…*
*He's… draining me?*

A pause.

Then—

"…Do you really think taking away my energy will do anything…?"

His voice came out direct.

Cold.

"…Huh?"

Aruko didn't respond.

Didn't move.

Jesio's grip loosened.

Then—

He let go.

The sword dropped.

Clink.

For a moment—

The entire arena felt it.

That shift.

That change.

Jesio slowly lifted his hand.

"…Let me show you…"

A beat.

"…how much I have."

This time—

There was anger.

Not loud.

Not wild.

But real.

“…3rd Work— Taiyō Yari.”

Light gathered.

Fast.

Violent.

A lance began to form in his hand—

Pure energy.

Blinding.

Expanding.

Growing larger—

And larger.

The air around it distorted.

Cracking under the pressure.

From the stands—

Nahori’s expression changed.

He leaned forward slightly.

“…This is bad.”

Beside him—

Elara’s fingers tightened.

“…That energy…”

Even Klein—

His eyes sharpened.

“…What is this…?”

A pause.

“…Can the 13 Radiant Volt Arts even reach this level…?”

The ground beneath Jesio trembled.

“AAAAA—!”

The lance grew even further.

The light—

Almost unbearable now.

Then—

It stabilized.

Compressed.

Condensed into his right hand.

Perfect.

Deadly.

Jesio looked forward.

Straight at Aruko.

“…Take this.”

He moved.

A single motion—

And the lance was gone.

No—

Thrown.

Too fast.

Too fast to see.

A flash tore through the arena.

Blinding.

The audience covered their eyes.

The air screamed.

Aruko’s eyes widened—

“…!”

His horn—

Glowed.

Dark energy surged.

Instinct.

He raised his sword—

Clang.

The impact hit.

And didn’t stop.

It pushed him back.

Dragging his feet across the ground.

The force—

Insane.

The sword absorbed—

Pulled—

Drank the energy.

But it wasn’t enough.

Not yet.

The lance kept pushing.

Kept burning.

"…!"

Aruko gritted his teeth.

Holding.

Barely.

The ground behind him cracked—

Breaking under the pressure.

*Too much…*
*I can't absorb all of this—*

His grip tightened.
*Not yet… hold… just a little longer…*

And then—

"…So slow."

Aruko's eyes widened.

*Behind me—?*
*No… I didn't even feel him move—*

Aruko's eyes shifted—

Too late.

Jesio stood there.

Already moving again.

His hand lifted.

"…Tenth Work— Kikō."

Energy condensed instantly.

Light—

Mixed with lightning.

Compressed into a small orb in his palm.

Dense.

Unstable.

For a fraction of a second—

Silence.

Then—

It detonated.

Right behind Aruko.

BOOM.

"…Ahh—!"

The explosion sent him flying.

His body thrown across the arena.

Rolling.

Crashing.

Pain tore through his back.
His body flew.

*I couldn't react…*
*That attack—*

He crashed hard.

*…He's stronger than I thought.*

He hit the ground hard.

Sliding to a stop.

Smoke rose.

His back—

Burned.

Blackened marks spread across it.

Jagged.

Like lightning had carved into his skin.

The air trembled.

Silence fell again.

Jesio stood still.

Looking at him.

Unmoved.

Unshaken.

“Its over.”

That’s what Jesio thought.

He turned away.

From the place where Aruko had fallen.

No hesitation.

No need to confirm.

For him—

It was already done.

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Silence filled the arena.

Heavy.

Uncertain.

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“Elara stood up from her seat.”

“…Arukoo!” she yelled.

Her voice broke through the stillness.

Nahori stood as well.

His eyes narrowed slightly.

“…He’s not dead.”

A pause.

“…I can feel his energy.”

The dust slowly began to settle.

The smoke cleared—

Bit by bit.

Aruko—

Was lying on the ground.

Still.

Unmoving.

Silence.

*…So this is it?*

His fingers twitched.

*No… not yet…*

A pulse.

*I can still move.*

His eyes slowly opened—
Pitch black.

*Then I'll keep going.*

His eyes—

Pitch black.

"…Is the match over…?"

The announcer's voice echoed.

Hesitant.

Unsure.

"The winner is—"

Before he could finish—

Aruko moved.

Gone.

A blur.

Faster than before—

No.

Different.

He appeared behind Jesio.

And—

Boom.

A bare punch.

Straight to his back.

Jesio's body snapped forward.

Thrown across the arena.

He crashed into the wall—

Hard.

The impact cracked the surface.

He dropped to the ground.

Silence.

Again.

But this time—

Heavier.

Aruko stood there.

Head lowered.

Not looking up.

Not saying anything.

Slowly—

He reached for his sword.

Picked it up.

"…What is that…?"

The announcer's voice shook.

"…What kind of power is that…?"

Nahori whispered.

His eyes locked onto Aruko.

Klein frowned.

"…Huh…?"

A pause.

“…What is this…?

Aruko tilted his head slightly.

The horn—

Still glowing.

Dark.

Deeper than before.

He brought the sword close.

Near his chest.

Held it there.

Tight.

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“…7th work— Utsarjana.”

The energy inside the blade—

Shifted.

Condensed.

Compressed to its limit.

The air around it—

Distorted.

Then—

It released.

A massive surge of energy blasted forward.

Straight toward Jesio—

Who was just getting up.

Barely standing.

The force tore through the ground.

Breaking everything in its path.

Just before it hit—

Jesio said something.

Quiet.

Too quiet.

No one heard it.

Then—

Impact.

The attack exploded through the wall behind him.

Blasting an entrance out of the arena itself.

Stone shattered.

Dust erupted.

A massive cloud of smoke filled everything.

No one moved.

Not the crowd.

Not the officials.

Not even the air felt like it was moving.

Something was wrong.

The silence—

Was unnatural.

Then—

A voice.

“…Hmm.. Something is wrong..”

Aruko said quietly.

His head still lowered.

His eyes—

Still black.

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**End of Chapter 14**